ʿIrfan: A Journey into Islamic Mysticism

An Introduction for Seekers

Based on a lecture series by
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Book Two · Expanded edition

DRAFT — not for distribution

An invitation

وَأَنِرْ أَبْصَارَ قُلُوبِنَا بِضِيَاءِ نَظَرِهَا إِلَيْكَ حَتَّىٰ تَخْرِقَ أَبْصَارُ الْقُلُوبِ حُجُبَ النُّورِ فَتَصِلَ إِلَىٰ مَعْدِنِ الْعَظَمَةِ

Enlighten the eyes of our hearts with the light of their looking at You to the extent that they penetrate the veils of light and reach the Source of Grandeur.[1]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

What is 'irfan?

> ***Point:*** *The prayers we already recite ask to see God with the heart and to be near Him, and the Imams wrote them for ordinary believers. We say the words, but seeking to know God does not feature in our daily routine; the obligations do. That less-practised side of the religion is called 'irfan, it is part of the Islam we know, and this book argues it is worth every believer's pursuit.*

These words come from the Munajat Sha'baniyyah, a prayer many of us recite in the month of Sha'ban. The line asks God to light up the eyes of our hearts with the light of looking at Him, until those eyes pass through even the veils of light and reach the source of His grandeur. It is a request to see God with the heart and to be near Him. Requests like this one were written for us, by the Imams ('a), as an endeavour for the ordinary believer.

[1] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165.

Despite saying these words in our munajats and on auspicious occasions, we find that seeking to know God does not feature in our day-to-day routine. Praying, fasting and paying what is due, the *wajibat*, are the dominant undertaking, and they are what most of us mean by practising the religion. The other side, the one the Munajat describes, in which the believer seeks to know God and to come near Him, is often less practised. That side of the religion is called *'irfan*.

'Irfan is the Arabic name for what English books call Islamic mysticism, and the two words do not say the same thing. "Mysticism" suggests mystery, something hidden and hard to pin down. The Arabic word names a kind of knowing. It shares its root with *ma'rifah*, knowledge, and an *'arif* is, in Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, "someone who knows".

The knowing meant here is not information about God. It is knowing Him from close, with the heart, which is what the Munajat asks for. In Murtada Mutahhari's words, the 'arif "wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it"[2]. 'Irfan is that knowing, and the training of the soul that makes it possible. It is part of the Islam we already know: its sources are the Qur'an and the words of the Imams, and the prayer at the head of this page is one of them.

This book argues that this side of the religion is worth every believer's pursuit. 'Irfan travels through the self and never leaves the shari'a. It is rooted in the Qur'an and the Imams. It is walked by a tested and ordered method. And it ends not in withdrawal from the world but in return: to people, with God, and to God Himself.

Who this book is for

> ***Point:*** *Any believer who prays, fasts and recites du'as, and has wondered whether the religion has another dimension. No background is needed; the book is a welcoming, brief introduction, with help on terms built in.*

The argument is addressed to anyone who prays, fasts and recites the du'as, and who has wondered whether there is more to these acts than getting them right; whether the religion has another dimension. No knowledge of 'irfan, of philosophy or of Arabic is assumed. The book is meant as a welcoming

[2] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.

introduction to ʿirfan, a guide to beginning the journey that strives for brevity and clarity. Each chapter opens with a section that details some of the words you'll meet, along with an explanation; all terms are gathered in the glossary at the end. Additional call-out sections are spread throughout with helpful context and short side notes.

How the book is built

> ***Point:*** *Five parts, each answering one question in order: why, through what, whose, how, and to what end.*

The book is built in five parts. Each answers one question and depends on the one before.

Part One, *The Call* (Chapters 1–3), asks why a believer should bother. It answers that the Qur'an invites more than the minimum, with the goal of ʿirfan already on our lips in our duʿas.

Part Two, *The Terrain* (Chapters 4–6), describes the landscape a traveller passes through on the journey towards ʿirfan: the self. It also sets out the boundary that keeps the traveller safe: the shariʿa.

Part Three, *The Travellers* (Chapters 7–9), asks whether ʿirfan is ours. It shows its roots in the Qur'an and the Imams, with a compatible view of similarities to Sufism.

Part Four, *The Road* (Chapters 10–15), asks how the path is walked: with a tested guide, through ordered stages, by repentance, discipline and love.

Part Five, *The Return* (Chapters 16–17), asks where the journey ends. The friends of God return to people, with God; every soul returns to God.

Where this book comes from

> ***Point:*** *The book is inspired by Sheikh Bahmanpour's lecture series, whose content and structure are its core. It adapts the lectures for print, adds context for a wider readership, draws on the Imams' texts and the great Shia scholars, footnotes every source, and presents differing views neutrally.*

This book is inspired by a lecture series on Islamic mysticism given by Sheikh M. S. Bahmanpour. The content and structure of those lectures are the core

of the book. Wherever the Sheikh is quoted directly, the words are his own, from that series.

Turning spoken lectures into a book has called for some editorial adaptation. To suit a wider readership, the book also adds context and explanation to support its main arguments. It draws on a wider literature as well: the words of the Imams in Nahj al-Balagha, al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya and the supplications of the Mafatih; then the great Shia teachers of the path, from Sayyid Haydar Amuli in the fourteenth century to modern scholars such as Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, ʻAllama Tabataba'i, Imam Khomeini and Ayatullah Mutahhari. Every source is given in a footnote, for readers who want to go further.

The finer questions of ʻirfan remain an ongoing conversation among our *ʻulama'*: whether a seeker needs a guide from the first step, how much solitude is wise, how far ordinary believers can travel. Where they differ, this book presents each view with neutrality.

What you can expect

> ***Point:*** *Three guiding principles frame the book: ʻirfan is not sought for powers; it needs no sect or order beside the Imam; and it never steps outside the shariʻa. By the end, a reader should be able to say what ʻirfan is and begin to practise it alongside the wajibat.*

Three guiding principles frame the discussions in the chapters that follow. The first is that ʻirfan is never pursued for the sake of powers, such as reading minds or foreseeing future events. Sheikh Bahmanpour and the wider literature agree on this, as Chapter 1 shows.

The second is that there is no separate sect or order through which ʻirfan must be gained. Shia ʻirfan has no institution of authority beside the Imam. How this position differs from that of the Sufi orders is explored in Chapter 9.

The third principle is the most important: no part of the journey towards ʻirfan requires stepping outside the shariʻa, and nothing on that journey is gained by doing so. The beginning of ʻirfan, as the Sheikh puts it, is the shariʻa. The inner path does not go around the law or rise above it; it is the law lived from the inside. Nothing in this book asks a reader to set aside the rulings of the jurists or the guidance of their marjaʻ. A fear that mysticism might do exactly that is one reason some scholars have been wary of ʻirfan. Chapter 8 sets out their wider concerns, with the answers given to them.

By the end, a reader should feel able to say what ‘irfan is and is not, why it belongs to us, and what the stages and dangers of the path entail. For those who wish to go further, each chapter and the epilogue offer small, practical steps for bringing this into daily life alongside the wajibat.

1

Seeking, not powers

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ ﴿٢١﴾

There are indeed signs in that for a people who reflect.

Qur'an 30:21

There is a verse often recited at weddings, one most of us know. In Surah al-Rum, God says that He created spouses for us from among ourselves "that you may take comfort in them", and that He ordained "affection and mercy" between husband and wife (Q 30:21). The verse ends with the words above: this is a sign for a people who reflect. Whether a person sees it depends on something in the person doing the looking. That something, and why it is worth developing, is the subject of this chapter.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *ʿIrfan*: knowing God from close · *maʿrifah*: knowledge of God · *ʿarif* (plural *ʿurafa'*): one who knows God · *muqarrabun*: those brought near to God · *awliya' Allah*: the friends of God · *shirk*: setting up a partner beside God

What the minimum leaves out

> ***Point:*** *The obligatory acts are enough for salvation, and that is not contested. What is contested is the claim that they are the whole of the religion. In Surah al-Rum the Qur'an asks for more than the minimum: it asks us to reflect on, know, listen to and reason about its signs.*

Let's start with two claims. The first is that a believer who prays, fasts, pays what is due and goes on hajj can hope for *jannah*, provided they do what is *wajib* and avoid what is forbidden. This claim is not contested. Sheikh Bahmanpour accepts it as fair for ordinary believers. Mohammad Ali Shomali makes the same point, describing the obligatory rules of fiqh as "the minimally necessary conditions of human perfection"[3].

The second claim goes further, and it is the one this book disputes. Some jurists and activists hold that the obligatory acts are the whole of the religion; anything beyond them, they say, is made up by the whims and wishes of certain mystics.

To see why there is more than the obligations, let's turn to the Qur'an and read on from the verse this chapter began with. Surah al-Rum names three more sets of signs: the creation of the heavens and the earth, with the variety of our languages and colours; our sleep and our work; the lightning, and the rain that revives the dead earth (Q 30:22–24). Each verse ends as the first did, by saying who the sign is for.

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّلْعَالِمِينَ ﴿٢٢﴾

There are indeed signs in that for those who know.

Qur'an 30:22

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَسْمَعُونَ ﴿٢٣﴾

There are indeed signs in that for a people who listen.

Qur'an 30:23

[3] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 17.

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَٰتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ ﴿٢٤﴾

There are indeed signs in that for people who exercise their reason.

Qur'an 30:24

Four times in a row, the Qur'an makes the same point. The signs are all around us: in marriage, in the people we meet, in sleep, in work, in the weather. Yet they are for those who reflect, know, listen and reason. This reflecting, knowing, listening and reasoning is what the Qur'an asks of us beyond the minimum.

For the avoidance of doubt, this invitation from the Qur'an is not an invitation to circumvent the law or to abandon the prescribed wajibat. Imam Khomeini insists that a genuine seeker's devotion "is within the bounds of the Shari'ah"[4]. Within those bounds, the Qur'an is just as insistent, in these verses and others, that it invites us to more than the obligatory acts.

Signs most people miss

> ***Point:*** *Most of us, the devout included, accept that the signs exist because the Qur'an says so, but we do not perceive them. The Qur'an describes that gap itself.*

An invitation addressed to those who reflect, know, listen and reason implies that many people do none of these things. Sheikh Bahmanpour does not limit this to the careless. Most pious people, he says, even those careful about the shari'a, do not find a sign in these verses. Looking at the variety of languages and colours, we are more likely to see a reason for division than a sign of God.

We have heard these verses many times, and we accept that there are signs in them because the Qur'an says so; yet accepting that a sign exists is not the same as perceiving it. The Qur'an describes the gap in one verse.

وَكَأَيِّن مِّنْ ءَايَةٍ فِي ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ يَمُرُّونَ عَلَيْهَا وَهُمْ عَنْهَا مُعْرِضُونَ ﴿١٠٥﴾

How many a sign there is in the heavens and the earth that they pass by while they are disregardful of it!

Qur'an 12:105

[4]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

‘Allama Tabataba’i explains what passing by a sign means; a person who sees a red light thinks of the danger it warns of, not of the colour and shape of the lamp. In the same way, the things of the world are signs, and “what the signs indicate is not this world, but the person of its Creator”[5]. Most of us see only the lamp. We witness the rain as rain and the marriage as a marriage, and we pass them by without perceiving what they say about their Creator.

The fault is in the receiver

> ***Point:*** *We miss the signs because an inner faculty in us, the soul’s ability to perceive, is not working. It exists and has only rusted, so it can be repaired. ‘Irfan is that repair.*

If the signs are present and plain, and yet we still pass them by, the fault is on our side. The Qur’an says where it lies, speaking of people who have every faculty and use none of them.

لَهُمْ قُلُوبٌ لَّا يَفْقَهُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَّا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ ءَاذَانٌ لَّا يَسْمَعُونَ بِهَآ ۚ
أُوْلَٰٓئِكَ كَٱلْأَنْعَٰمِ بَلْ هُمْ أَضَلُّ

they have hearts with which they do not understand, they have eyes with which they do not see, they have ears with which they do not hear. They are like cattle; indeed, they are more astray.

Qur’an 7:179

Cattle see and hear perfectly well, so the comparison cannot be about the senses. Sheikh Bahmanpour reads it as being about what lies behind the senses. Eyes and ears take in the surface of things, whereas inside a human being there should be something more: a faculty, which animals lack, that turns what the senses take in into understanding. In most of us, he says, it is not working.

He compares this faculty to a machine. The ear catches the sound, but “there is something inside which doesn’t catch it. There is a machine inside which is [rusted].” That machine is the soul. It has to be repaired before it can catch the signals of God. For Sheikh Bahmanpour, this is the whole subject in one sentence: mysticism is about making the soul hear, see and reflect. He adds that this is not easy, and requires a great deal of training.

[5] Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 6–7.

Placing the fault in the receiver has two consequences. The first is that the problem is not a shortage of evidence. God is not withholding signs; we are failing to receive them.

The second is that the problem can be solved. A faculty that exists but has rusted can be repaired; one that is absent cannot be made fit for purpose. The *Kernel of the Kernels*, a record of ‘Allama Tabataba’i’s early lectures on the path, opens by saying that the pull towards the unseen is “part of the innate instincts of the human being”[6]. The longing for God, and the faculty that perceives Him, are part of how we are made.

Repair is only the start. Once the inner faculty begins to work, Sheikh Bahmanpour says, the journey begins, and it does not end; it is a path that “has a beginning and no end”.

Some do see

> ***Point:*** *The Qur’an describes believers in whom this faculty works: hearts that tremble at God’s mention, those who know, those who fear Him, the friends of God. These are the people the tradition calls the ‘urafa’.*

If the faculty can be repaired, there should be people in whom it already works. The Qur’an describes them more than once. Sheikh Bahmanpour divides people into two groups: those whose souls work, and those whose souls do not. He calls the first group the *‘urafa’*, the plural of *‘arif*. He sets the prophets and the Imams (‘a) aside as a class of their own, and looks at ordinary believers who see more than the rest. The first description of them is in Surah al-Anfal.

إِنَّمَا ٱلْمُؤْمِنُونَ ٱلَّذِينَ إِذَا ذُكِرَ ٱللَّهُ وَجِلَتْ قُلُوبُهُمْ

The faithful are only those whose hearts tremble [with awe] when Allah is mentioned,

Qur’an 8:2

A heart trembles only at the mention of someone it has some experience of; a name means little to a person who does not know whom it names. The

[6] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 4.

believers of this verse are thus the believers who know Allah. A verse in Surah Al ʻImran goes further, giving them another name.

شَهِدَ ٱللَّهُ أَنَّهُۥ لَآ إِلَٰهَ إِلَّا هُوَ وَٱلْمَلَٰٓئِكَةُ وَأُو۟لُوا۟ ٱلْعِلْمِ

Allah ... bears witness that there is no god except Him, and [so do] the angels and those who possess knowledge.

Qur'an 3:18

Sheikh Bahmanpour reads "those who possess knowledge" as another name for the ʻurafa'. Every Muslim knows that there is no god but Allah. Our knowledge of *tawhid*, God's oneness, is still not the knowledge of those who witness it. Tawhid is simple to say and hard to grasp; in the Sheikh's view, the intellect alone cannot reach its depths, and only the awakened soul can. Surah Fatir describes the same people by what they feel.

إِنَّمَا يَخْشَى ٱللَّهَ مِنْ عِبَادِهِ ٱلْعُلَمَٰٓؤُا۟

Only those of Allah's servants having knowledge fear Him.

Qur'an 35:28

Most of us fear Allah's punishment. The people of this verse fear Him with a fear that is not about punishment at all.

Surah Yunus adds to their names, which Sheikh Bahmanpour treats as the same people: the *awliya' Allah*, the friends of God (Q 10:62). Imam ʻAli (ʻa) describes what these friends see that others miss.

[√ERIFY: Arabic of Nahj 3.403 from Qutbuddin p. 810|

God's special devotees are those who perceive the world's reality when others are deceived by her appearance. They occupy themselves with what is coming when others occupy themselves with the present.[7]

Nahj al-Balagha

[7] Imam ʻAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 3.403.

Other people look at the surface of the world; the friends of God look at what lies inside it. Sheikh Bahmanpour is careful about what this means. There is nothing wrong with pursuing material wealth in this life; the trouble is being solely occupied with it. The friends of God have families, friends and a place in society, as we do. They think not about themselves but about God, and in their hearts they are cut off from everything else.

What they are given, and why it is open to all

> ***Point:*** *The Qur'an promises these people nearness to God, a good life, and freedom from fear and grief. Their rank is open to any believer who obeys God and acts righteously. Together, these make the case for pursuing ʻirfan.*

The Qur'an also tells us what these people receive. The first gift is nearness: Surah al-Waqiʻa sorts people on the Last Day, and at the top it places the Foremost Ones.

وَٱلسَّـٰبِقُونَ ٱلسَّـٰبِقُونَ ﴿١٠﴾ أُو۟لَـٰٓئِكَ ٱلْمُقَرَّبُونَ ﴿١١﴾

And the Foremost Ones are the foremost ones: they are the ones brought near [to Allah],

Qur'an 56:10-11

The Arabic for "brought near" is *muqarrabun*. God is not far from anyone, Sheikh Bahmanpour points out; being brought near means that a veil between the person and God has been removed, so that they understand far more.

The second gift is a different kind of life, promised in Surah al-Nahl to whoever acts righteously, man or woman, while having faith.

مَنْ عَمِلَ صَـٰلِحًا مِّن ذَكَرٍ أَوْ أُنثَىٰ وَهُوَ مُؤْمِنٌ فَلَنُحْيِيَنَّهُۥ حَيَوٰةً طَيِّبَةً

Whoever acts righteously, [whether] male or female, should he be faithful, We shall revive him with a good life

Qur'an 16:97

This good life, *hayat tayyiba*, is in Sheikh Bahmanpour's reading a clean life. Its people live in the world without being soiled by it, rising above the worries that occupy everyone else. This good life, he says, is what the mystics seek.

The third gift is peace, promised in the verse of Surah Yunus that names the friends of God.

أَلَآ إِنَّ أَوْلِيَآءَ ٱللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ ﴿٦٢﴾

Look! The friends of Allah will indeed have no fear nor will they grieve

Qur'an 10:62

For the muqarrabun, Sheikh Bahmanpour says, the terms are entirely different from those of ordinary believers.

None of this would matter to an ordinary reader if it were reserved for prophets. Surah al-Nisa' answers that concern.

وَمَن يُطِعِ ٱللَّهَ وَٱلرَّسُولَ فَأُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ مَعَ ٱلَّذِينَ أَنْعَمَ ٱللَّهُ عَلَيْهِم مِّنَ ٱلنَّبِيِّـۧنَ وَٱلصِّدِّيقِينَ وَٱلشُّهَدَآءِ وَٱلصَّٰلِحِينَ وَحَسُنَ أُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ رَفِيقًا ﴿٦٩﴾

Whoever obeys Allah and the Apostle—they are with those whom Allah has blessed, including the prophets and the truthful, the martyrs and the righteous, and excellent companions are they!

Qur'an 4:69

Sheikh Bahmanpour reads this verse as naming four ranks of those God has blessed: the prophets; the truthful (*siddiqin*); the *shuhada'*, which the translation used here renders "martyrs" and which he takes as "the witnesses"; and the righteous (*salihin*). The first three ranks, he says, are beyond us; the fourth is a doorway. The salihin are those able to receive this favour, and from among them God chooses the truthful and the prophets. The way in is righteous action, as the verse on the good life also says.

That doorway is open to people like us: ordinary people, he says, can also enter the realm of the muqarrabun. It is difficult, he says, but it is open, because we are made for it. We call ourselves human beings, yet he says "we are not yet human beings". We begin with the potential to become human in the full sense that the prophets are. He means this as a statement of what we

were made for. A human being, he says, has the capacity to become a friend of God; God created us with that capacity, and wants us to reach it.

This is the case for pursuing ‘irfan. The Qur’an invites more than the minimum, and what stands in the way is a faculty in us that can be repaired. On the other side of that repair lie nearness to God, a good life, and freedom from fear and grief. That rank is open to any believer who obeys God and the Prophet and acts righteously.

The aim is God, not powers

> ***Point:*** *Training the soul can aim at powers or at God. Sheikh Bahmanpour calls powers sought this way shirk. Tabataba’i, Khomeini and Mutahhari each agree in their own way: the aim of ‘irfan is God alone.*

Pursuing ‘irfan means training the soul, and soul-training is not unique to Islam. People take up the inner life for different reasons. Some train the soul in an attempt to gain power: to be in two places at once, to see the future or the past, or to master the hidden world of the soul. Sheikh Bahmanpour says this kind of mysticism must be held apart from the real thing. Islamic mysticism is about catching the signs of Allah: becoming sensitive to them, and learning to hear and see.

He ended his first lecture more strongly. ‘Irfan “is not about any type of power or empowering the soul” to work *karamat* and *mu‘jizat*, the wonders of the saints and the miracles of the prophets. Then: “These are shirk.” *Shirk*, setting up a partner beside God, is the gravest charge in Islam. [QUERY: L01 ¶32, "These are shirk": does "these" mean seeking karamat and mu‘jizat, or the powers themselves? Confirm with the lecturer.]

The great teachers of the Shia tradition make closely related points, each in his own words. ‘Allama Tabataba’i tells the traveller that he “has no right to seek occult experiences and miraculous qualities”, nor to perform austerities or recite invocations to gain powers such as crossing great distances in a moment or reading the thoughts of others. Whoever does so “does not move on the path of the Beloved’s pleasure and his worship is not for the sake of God”. It is his own self that he worships, “though he may not admit it by word of mouth”[8].

[8] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), pp. 28–29.

◈ WHO'S WHO: ʿALLAMA TABATABA'I

Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Tabataba'i is best known as the author of *al-Mizan*, a commentary on the Qur'an in twenty volumes[9]. His student Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Husayni Tihrani describes him as having flown "with the two wings of knowledge and action". He travelled the path in both philosophy and gnosis under the guidance of the gnostic Mirza ʿAli Aqa Qadi, and after years of philosophical argument he "came to settle down at the sacred threshold of the Qur'an"[10]. *Kernel of the Kernels* (*Lubb al-Lubab*) is Tihrani's record of the lectures on ethics and gnosis that Tabataba'i gave to students in Qum in 1949–50[11]. He also wrote the preface to *Light Within Me*[12], from which several quotations in this chapter come.

Imam Khomeini reports the test his teacher Ayatullah Shahabadi used: the measure of true spiritual effort is how much selfishness is in it. If a traveller's "spiritual exercises are meant for acquiring powers for worldly ends, his efforts are rendered invalid"[13].

Murtada Mutahhari uses the same word as Sheikh Bahmanpour. The ʿurafa', he writes, consider it "a kind of shirk (polytheism) for one's goal in life and particularly in worship to be something other than God Himself", and he recalls Imam ʿAli (ʿa) saying that he worshipped God not from fear of His Fire or desire for His Paradise but because he found Him worthy of worship[14].

The scholars differ in emphasis but agree that powers are not the aim. Sheikh Bahmanpour calls such powers shirk. Mutahhari explains why seeking them would be so: the goal has become something other than God.

Seeking, and nothing else

Point: *ʿIrfan is seeking God, the knowledge and love of Him, and nothing else. The chapter's conclusion follows: ʿirfan is worth pursuing, as the training of the soul to perceive and love God, open to every believer and sought for God alone.*

[9] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 30.
[10] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 8.
[11] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 9.
[12] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.
[13] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.
[14] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 44.

With powers set aside, what remains is the definition Sheikh Bahmanpour gave at the end of his first lecture: ʿirfan "is actually seeking and nothing else". It seeks two things: *maʿrifah*, the knowledge of God; and the love of God.

> ع **WORD STUDY: ʿIRFAN AND MAʿRIFAH**
> *ʿIrfan*, *maʿrifah*, *ʿarif* and its plural *ʿurafa'* belong to one family of words about knowing. An ʿarif, as Sheikh Bahmanpour puts it, is "someone who knows". "Mystic" is used of Christians, Hindus and Buddhists alike; ʿarif is the Islamic word, and it makes a precise claim. Murtada Mutahhari draws the line. The philosopher wants a correct picture of the world in his mind. The ʿarif "wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it"[15]. *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (ʿa), says that there is no way to God except through knowledge[16]. What kind of knowledge that is, and how it differs from what we learn from books, is the subject of Chapter 3.

ʿAllama Tabataba'i's definition agrees: "The real gnostic is he who worships Allah not, because he hopes for any reward or is afraid of any punishment, but only because he knows Him and loves Him"[17].

ʿIrfan is therefore worth pursuing: it is the training of the soul to perceive and love God, open to every believer, and sought for God alone.

If the aim is to know and love God, what does that longing sound like?

> ➤ **TRY THIS**
> Sheikh Bahmanpour built his first lesson on the four signs of Surah al-Rum. For one week, read Q 30:21–24 slowly once a day. After each verse, ask yourself what he found in its ending: whether you reflect, whether you know, whether you listen and whether you use your reason. Then, at some point in the day, notice one of the four signs where it occurs in your life: the affection in your home, the languages and colours of the people you meet, your own sleep and the work that earns your living, or the rain.

[15] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.
[16] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʿa), p. 9.
[17] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.